Around 261/260 BCE Ashoka fought the first and possibly only large-scale war of his reign, at Kalinga. This is the only conquest he mentions here, and since no other territorial victory figures in any of his later edicts it can be presumed that this was his only major military battle.[1] The number displaced (‘one hundred and fifty thousand’), killed (‘one hundred thousand’), and dead as a consequence of the war (‘many times as many those who died’) make it clear that this was warfare on a very considerable scale,[2] even if one discounts the tendency to top up the headcount by offering epic figures rounded off to the nearest hundred thousand. The carnage also seems to have brought suffering indiscriminately upon all—Brahmans, Shramanas, other sects, households—many among them people who had actually practised the dhamma that Ashoka now espoused.[3] The future protocols for human relationship that would come to define the emperor’s idea of dhamma—from obedience to parents to proper courtesy towards slaves and servants—were those that the king now saw as having been already lived by many whom he had slaughtered, dispossessed, and deported. He describes his victory as deplorable because of the blind uniformity with which he had inflicted misery, the ironic democracy of suffering he had created.

What he proceeded to do in the immediate aftermath of Kalinga is unknown. Certainly, he lost all appetite for conquering new territory and soon, he became a Buddhist. Within a couple of years, in the tenth year after his coronation, we see him on a pilgrimage to Mahabodhi, where the Buddha had attained enlightenment roughly 300 years earlier. This was the beginning of what Ashoka describes as the second part of his reign, a watershed in the conduct of his personal and political life.

He now undertook what were described as ‘dharma yatras’ instead of the usual royal ‘vihara yatras’. Vihara yatras were marked by pleasures such as the hunt; Ashoka’s yatras were mass contact programmes involving donations and guidance on dhamma: ‘On these (tours) the following takes